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LIFE SCIENCES INSIGHTS

COMMERCIAL STRATEGY

Real-World Data. Real Competitive Edge.

How pharma affiliates are turning country-level data into commercial advantage — before it shows up in the quarterly audit.

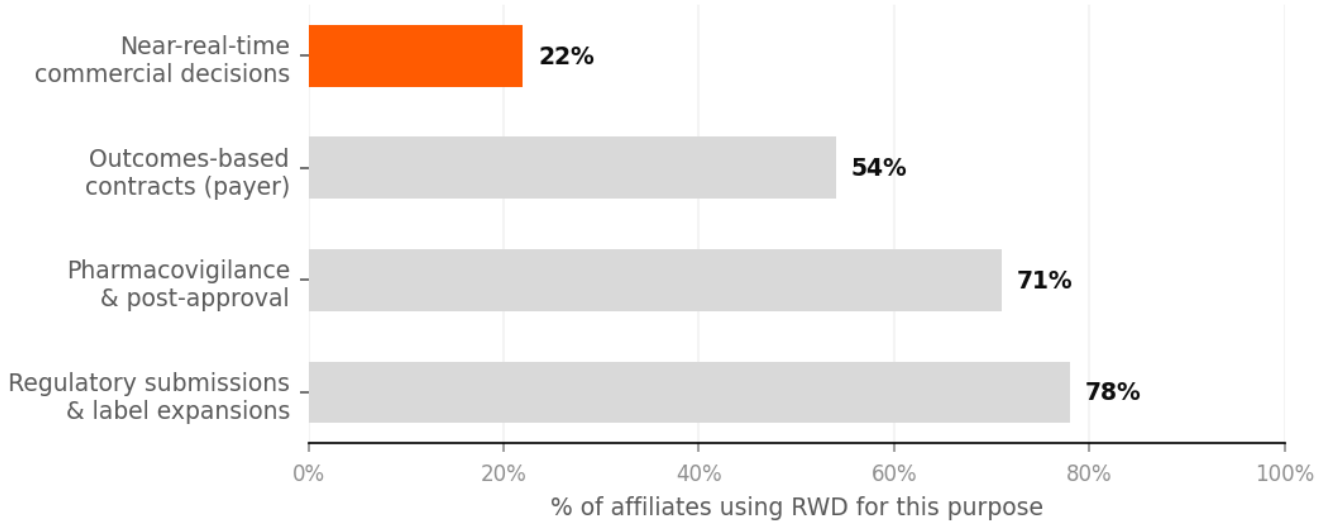
Juan Roberts
Europe Partner, TheMindCo
2026

RWE HAS A BLIND SPOT

Most pharma companies have been collecting real-world data for years.
Few are using it to win commercially.

Real-world evidence earned its place in pharma's toolkit through regulatory affairs — post-approval studies, HTA dossiers, label expansions. That work is essential. But it answers questions from the past.

When a competitor starts gaining share in second-line, that signal doesn't appear in your next regulatory submission. It appears in your sales results — six months later. By then, the market has already moved.



Source: Adapted from IQVIA Institute 2025; PwC Life Sciences Real-World Data Survey 2025

THE RETROSPECTIVE TRAP

RWE was built for regulators. Not for competitive decisions.

POST-APPROVAL STUDIES

Designed for pharmacovigilance commitments — not commercial speed.

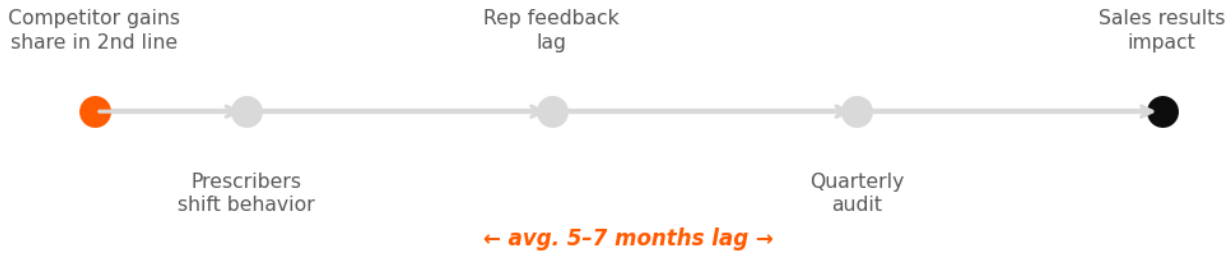
REGULATORY SUBMISSIONS

Support label expansions and HTA negotiations. Retrospective by design.

OUTCOMES-BASED CONTRACTS

Valuable for payer dialogue. Still backward-looking by nature.

All valuable. All retrospective. All too slow for the competitive game.



Illustrative timeline based on affiliate commercial intelligence benchmarking

> *"In God we trust. All others must bring data."*
> **— W. EDWARDS DEMING**

STRATEGY PRINCIPLE #1

Track what moves markets — in near real-time.

The affiliates pulling ahead aren't waiting for the quarterly audit. They're using country-level claims data, prescribing registries, and EHR feeds to detect competitive shifts as they happen.

PRESCRIBING PATTERNS

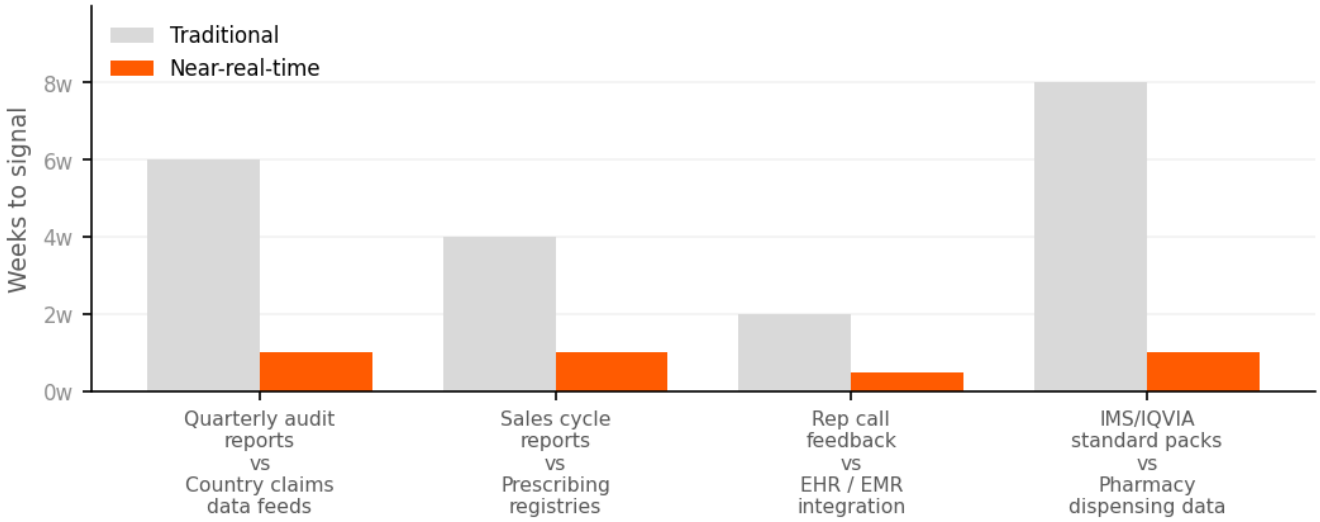
Who writes what, in which patient segment — and why that is shifting across geographies.

TREATMENT SEQUENCING

Line-of-therapy shifts before they appear in quarterly audits or rep call reports.

SWITCHING BEHAVIOR

Which patients are leaving, to which brand, and the prescriber patterns driving it.



Weeks-to-signal comparison across data source types; TMC affiliate benchmarking 2025

The data exists at country level. The question is who has built the capability to use it.

STRATEGY PRINCIPLE #2

The data exists.
Most affiliates aren't using it.

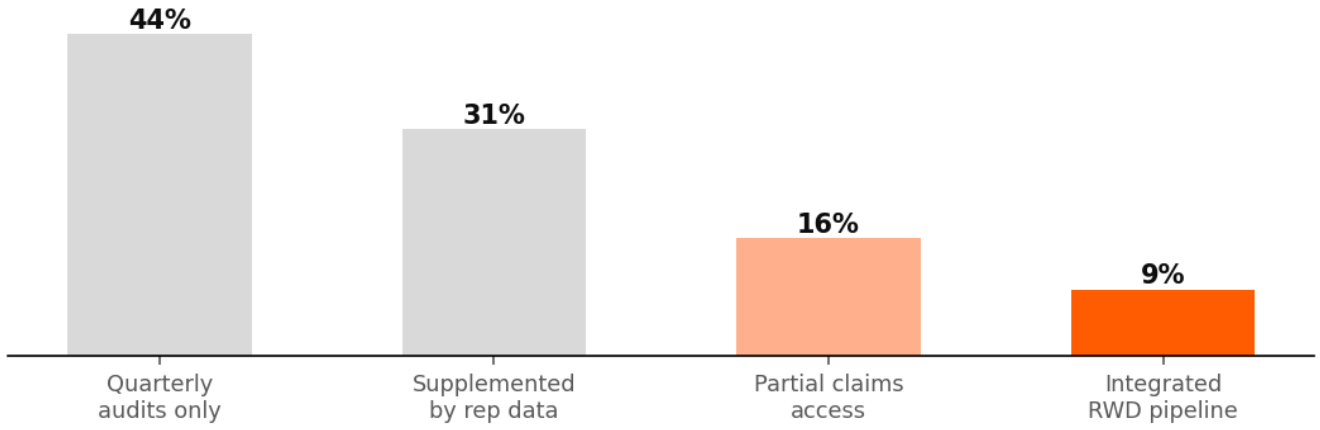
Country-level claims data, prescribing registries, and EHR integrations exist across virtually every major European market. They are accessible — but access requires local negotiation, technical infrastructure, and analytical capability that most affiliates have not built.

40%

of pharma executives rate real-world data as **'critical'** to commercial strategy

9%

of EU affiliates have a fully integrated near-real-time RWD pipeline



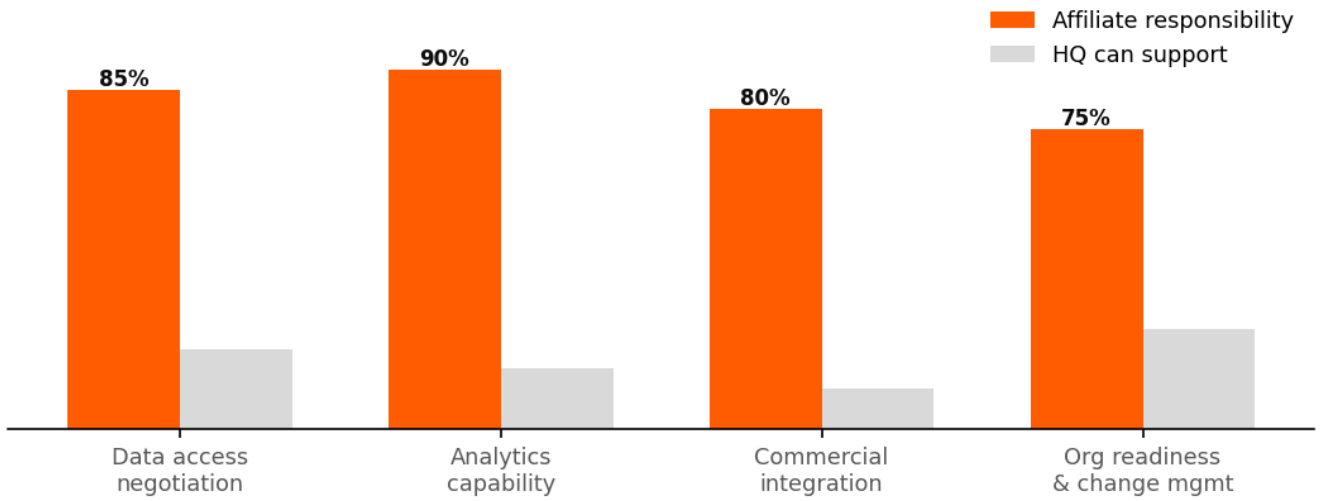
Source: PwC Life Sciences Real-World Data Survey 2025; TMC EU affiliate benchmarking

STRATEGY PRINCIPLE #3

HQ won't build this for you.
The capability has to live in the affiliate.

Country-level data access has to be negotiated locally — with data providers, with health systems, with payers. The analytical capability to interpret it has to be embedded in the affiliate's commercial team.

This isn't a technology problem. It's a capability problem. The affiliates that have built this aren't just better at reporting — they compete differently. They move faster, they anticipate competitor actions, and they allocate field resources based on forward-looking signals rather than backward-looking results.



TMC affiliate capability assessment framework; n=42 EU pharma affiliates, 2024–2025

> *"The goal is to turn data into information, and information into insight."*
> **— CARLY FIORINA**

THE GAP IS ALREADY VISIBLE

The affiliates that act now will be impossible to catch.

The gap between affiliates that have near-real-time commercial intelligence and those that don't is already visible. It will only get wider — because the advantage compounds. Every quarter of early signal detection translates into faster resource reallocation, better field targeting, and more effective response to competitive moves.

START WITH PRESCRIBING DATA

Map your country-level data landscape. Identify which claims and registry sources are accessible and at what cost.

BUILD INTERNAL CAPABILITY

Embed analytical literacy in your commercial team. The bottleneck is never the data — it's the people who can act on it.

MOVE FROM RETROSPECTIVE TO PROSPECTIVE

Replace quarterly audit reviews with rolling signal-detection workflows tied directly to field planning cycles.

NEGOTIATE ACCESS LOCALLY

HQ sets the framework. Affiliates close the deals. Country-level data partnerships require local relationships and local accountability.

"Where does your affiliate sit on this capability curve? That's the question worth answering today."

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About TheMindCo

We are a strategy and research firm dedicated to supporting growth, delivering original insights, and tackling complex strategic issues. Founded in 2006 by McKinsey and Booz Allen Hamilton alumni, our mission is to support growth and innovation globally through hard-to-reach insights, advanced analytics, and strategic storytelling.

20+
Years of experience

600+
Projects delivered

50+
Clients worldwide

STRATEGY & INNOVATION

Commercial strategy, competitive intelligence, growth architecture

RESEARCH & INSIGHTS

Qualitative & quantitative research, stakeholder mapping, market intelligence

AI & ANALYTICS

Data pipelines, predictive modeling, commercial analytics platforms

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ABOUT THE AUTHOR

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Europe Partner, TheMindCo

Juan leads TheMindCo's European practice, working with pharma, medtech, and life sciences companies on the commercial and strategic decisions where getting it wrong is costly.

His work sits at the intersection of real-world data, affiliate commercial strategy, and competitive intelligence — helping European affiliates build the capability to move from retrospective reporting to forward-looking decision-making.

Before TheMindCo, Juan held strategy and commercial roles across the pharma value chain in the UK, Spain, and Argentina.

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